Chouhan Woos Wo

The MP chief minister lavishes female electors with a whole bonanza of women-

By RAHUL NORONHA

In

just about eight months from now, Shivraj Singh Chouhan will be leading the BJP to elections as the incumbent chief minister of Madhya Pradesh—for the fourth time. Even as battle lines are being drawn and the electoral narrative honed, Chouhan has chosen to pivot his election strategy on a tried and tested demographic—the state's nearly 26 million women voters.

To reiterate his commitment towards improving their lot, Chouhan has come up with the Ladli Behana Yojana (LBY), a welfare scheme for the state's women not covered under any of his previous schemes such as the Ladli Laxmi Yojana. Existing schemes are being dovetailed with the larger plan to target women. In the budget announced on March 2, a third of the Rs 3.14 lakh crore allocation went directly to the cohort. Clearly, *mama* (maternal uncle) is more than ever betting on his *bhanji*s (nieces) in his fourth election. Will they stand by him in 2023?

The LBY entails a payout of Rs 1,000 a month to women between the ages of 23 and 59,



MAKING A FAIR PITCH
Chouhan addresses beneficiaries at the launch of the Mukhyamantri Ladli Behana Yojana in Bhopal, Mar. 5